

revenue to sustain application development. This affects the whole global economy as funds are relayed from other sectors which results in less investment in marketing and research.

The following constitute software piracy:

- ▶ Loading unlicensed software on your PC
- ▶ Using single-licensed software on multiple computers
- ▶ Using a key generator to circumvent copy protection
- ▶ Distributing a licensed or unlicensed (“cracked”) version of software over the internet and offline

“Cloning” is another threat. It happens when someone copies the idea behind your software and writes his own code. Since ideas are not copy protected across borders all the time, this isn’t strictly illegal.

A software “crack” is an illegally obtained version of the software which works its way around the encoded copy prevention. Users of pirated software may use a key generator to generate a “serial” number which unlocks an evaluation version of the software, thus defeating the copy protection. Software cracking and using unauthorised keys are illegal acts of copyright infringement.

Using pirated material comes with its own risks. The pirated software may contain Trojans, viruses, worms and other malware, since pirates will often infect software with malicious code. Users of pirated software may be punished by the law for illegal use of copyrighted material. Plus you won’t get the software support that is provided by the developers.

To protect your software from piracy if you’re a developer, you should apply strong safeguards. Some web sites sell software with a “digital fingerprint” that helps in tracing back the pirated copies to the source. Another common method is hardware locking. Using this, the software license is locked to a specific computer hardware, such that it runs only on that computer. Unfortunately, hackers continue to find their way around these measures.

13. Others

So far we’ve discussed the dedicated methods of committing cyber crimes. In a nutshell, any offence committed using electronic means such as net extortion, cyber bullying, child pornography and internet fraud is termed as cyber crime.

The internet is a huge breeding ground for pornography, which has often been subject to censorship on grounds of obscenity. But what may be considered obscene in India, might not be considered so in other countries.